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IMAGE SUPER-RESOLUTION

Deep Learning Project Report

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1 Introduction and Motivation

Single-image Super-resolution is the task of upscaling a low-resolution image into a higher-resolution one, without losing details or introducing artefacts such as in classical methods (e.g., bicubic). Enhancing the resolution of an image from low-resolution (LR) to high resolution (HR) matters in applications such as surveillance cameras and in image and video compression.

In this project, we focus on learning-based super-resolution methods and implement a deep neural network to upscale images by a factor of $\times 4$, following the project guidelines. We use the DIV2K dataset, where low-resolution images are generated using bicubic downsampling, and train the model on image patches rather than full images to increase the number of training samples and improve generalization. After holding out 10 images for validation, training runs on the remaining 790.

We implement the Enhanced Deep Residual Network (EDSR) architecture, which processes the low-resolution input directly and performs upsampling. The model learns to reconstruct high-frequency details from data. Our main objective is to correctly implement the full training and evaluation pipeline and analyze the effect of the model on both quantitative metrics and visual quality.

We chose this task because, unlike classification, it requires the model to produce an entire image as output, which makes it far more sensitive to architectural choices and to how carefully the results are measured. That sensitivity is the subject of this report.

2 Brief Literature Review

To better understand our approach, it is useful to review the evolution of image super-resolution methods.

2.1 Interpolation Methods (The Baseline)

One of the most traditional approaches to image upscaling is bicubic interpolation. This method estimates the value of a new pixel by computing a weighted average of its 16 nearest pixels in the low-resolution image.

The main advantage of bicubic interpolation is its low computational cost, which allows it to run efficiently in real-time on almost any device. However, since this method only uses the existing pixel values, it is unable to generate new high-frequency details. As a result, the upscale images often appear overly smooth, with blurred edges and missing textures.

In this project, we use bicubic interpolation as a baseline method to quantitatively and qualitatively evaluate the improvement achieved by learning-based super-resolution models.

2.2 Early Deep Learning (SRCNN)

The field of single image super-resolution changed significantly with the introduction of the **Super-Resolution Convolutional Neural Network (SRCNN)** by Dong et al. [2]. This was one of the first methods to use a convolutional neural network to directly learn the mapping from low-resolution images to high-resolution images.

Although SRCNN demonstrated that deep learning models could outperform classical interpolation methods, it had an important limitation. The low-resolution image first needed to be upscaled using bicubic interpolation before being passed to the network. This increased the computational cost, as the network had to process high-resolution feature maps, making the approach slower and less efficient.

Two further methods appear in our results table as baselines. A+ [1] is the strongest of the pre-deep-learning approaches and works by matching each low-resolution patch to an entry in a learned dictionary and applying a linear regressor attached to that entry. VDSR [3] stacks 20 convolutional layers and predicts only the difference between the bicubic-upsampled input and the ground truth, which is easier to learn than the image itself. Like SRCNN it still runs every layer at high resolution.

2.3 State-of-the-Art (EDSR)

Building on the idea of residual learning, Lim et al. proposed the Enhanced Deep Residual Network (EDSR) [4]. What they argued is that Batch Normalization, standard in residual networks for image classification, is the wrong tool for super-resolution.

The problem is what it normalizes away. Batch Normalization rescales each feature map to zero mean and unit variance, which discards the absolute scale of the features. A classifier does not care about that, since a cat is a cat whether the photo is bright or dark. Here it matters, because what we are predicting *is* pixel intensity, and the range information the layer removes is the thing we are trying to reproduce. It also ties each output to the other images in the batch, which is odd for a task where every image is reconstructed on its own, and it behaves differently at test time because the layer then uses statistics collected during training instead of statistics from the image in front of it.

There is a practical cost as well. A Batch Normalization layer takes up roughly as much memory as the convolution it follows. Dropping it left enough room to make the network deeper and wider, and that extra capacity turned out to be worth more than the normalization had been.

By removing Batch Normalization layers, the authors were able to design a deeper and wider network that produces more accurate and visually consistent high-resolution images. Due to its strong performance and relatively simple design, EDSR has become a commonly used architecture for image super-resolution and is the model selected for this project.

3 Methodology and Model Description

In this section, we describe the proposed super-resolution method and the architecture of the implemented EDSR model. We also outline the training procedure and key implementation details relevant to our experiments.

3.1 Model Architecture (EDSR)

The network has three components: a data normalization layer, a deep residual body that extracts features at low resolution, and an upsampling module that raises the spatial resolution by $\times 4$ at the very end.

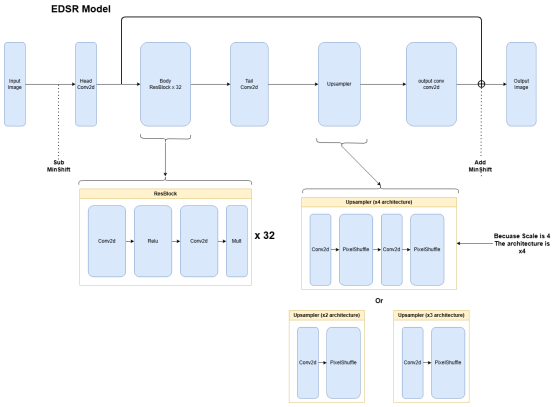


Figure 1: EDSR Model

3.1.1 Data Normalization (MeanShift)

The input image is passed through a MeanShift layer. This layer subtracts the average RGB values of the DIV2K dataset from the input image. By centering the data distribution around zero, the network can focus on learning structural patterns such as edges and textures instead of adapting to absolute brightness differences. This normalization helps stabilize training and leads to faster convergence. The layer holds the channel means as fixed constants and is never trained.

3.1.2 Residual Blocks (ResBlock)

The core of the EDSR model is a deep stack of residual blocks used for feature extraction. In our implementation, the network consists of 32 residual blocks, each with 128 feature maps, allowing the model to learn rich image representations while maintaining stable gradient flow through skip connections.

Unlike standard residual blocks used in image classification, the Batch Normalization layers are removed, for the reasons given in Section 2.3. Each block is therefore convolution, ReLU, convolution, added to its own input.

3.1.3 Upsampling Module (PixelShuffle)

After feature extraction, the learned feature maps are passed to the upsampling module. We use the PixelShuffle operation to increase the spatial resolution of the image. Unlike transposed convolution layers, which can introduce checkerboard artifacts, PixelShuffle rearranges feature maps to expand the height and width of the image in a deterministic manner.

This approach allows the network to perform the $\times 4$ upscaling entirely at the end of the model, as two successive $\times 2$ PixelShuffle stages, resulting in efficient computation and improved visual quality of the reconstructed high-resolution images.

3.2 Training and Implementation Details

The EDSR model was trained using a patch-based learning strategy to increase the number of training samples and improve generalization. From each training image, 20 random low-resolution patches of size 48×48 were extracted per epoch.

Training was performed using a batch size of 32 and optimized with the Adam optimizer with an initial learning rate of 1×10^{-4}, halved at epochs 25 and 40 by a MultiStepLR schedule ($1 \times 10^{-4} \rightarrow 5 \times 10^{-5} \rightarrow 2.5 \times 10^{-5}$). The network was trained for 100 epochs with the L1 loss as the objective function, following the EDSR paper, which reports that it trains more stably and gives sharper results than a squared error loss. We did not test this ourselves.

Since the 100 DIV2K validation images are used as our test set, we could not also use them to select the model. Instead, we held out 10 images from the training set and used them for the per-epoch validation and checkpoint selection (this is what Figure 2 shows). The test set was evaluated only once, at the end, with the best checkpoint.

3.3 Hardware and Experimental Setup

All experiments were conducted on VUB GPU Farm (ETROFARM) equipped with CPU AMD EPYC 9124(F. 25 M.17), 2 sockets, 2x16x1= 32 (logical) CPU, 377GB, 4x Nvidia A100(Ampere) 80GB, Nvidia Driver: 535.247.01, CUDA 12.1.1. This hardware setup was sufficient to support patch-based training with moderate batch sizes and allowed the EDSR model to be trained efficiently for the required number of epochs. The same experimental setup was used consistently across all experiments to ensure fair and reproducible results.

3.4 Code Structure and Reproducibility

The code is structured so that anyone can check our results or repeat them.

The two evaluation functions from fix 3 are now one `evaluate` function that takes the prediction routine as an argument. We push the model, the bicubic baseline and the self-ensemble through it, so none of them can be scored differently by accident. We

simplified the metric code in the same pass. The old `PSNR` and `SSIM` classes are plain functions now (`calc_psnr`, `calc_ssim`, `rgb_to_y`, `shave_border`), and the two luminance conversions that had drifted apart are a single function.

The dataset comes from the four official DIV2K archives at ETH Zurich rather than a zip file on someone's personal cloud drive, so anyone can get exactly the data we used. We seed every random number generator from one value. That includes the dataloader workers, which previously inherited the same seed and handed back correlated crops. The generator state also goes into the checkpoint, so a resumed run continues the same sequence instead of starting a new one.

The project also ships with the scripts we actually used. A smoke test runs the whole pipeline on a handful of images in a few minutes, which catches shape and path errors before we queue a job that takes hours. A second script runs the notebook end to end on the GPU farm and writes three things into a per-run folder: the executed notebook, an HTML copy of it, and a record of the software environment. Every number in this report has one of those folders behind it, so we can point at the code that produced it and the package versions it ran against.

4 Experimental Results and Discussion

We evaluated the performance of our model using quantitative metrics and qualitative visual inspection.

4.1 Testing Utilities

We implemented three helper functions used during testing that help with evaluation.

Shave border. When computing quantitative metrics, the outer pixels of the output image may contain padding artifacts. Therefore, we cropped a border equal to the scaling factor from both the prediction and the ground truth before evaluation, so that PSNR, SSIM and LPIPS are all computed on exactly the same pixels.

Geometric ensemble. We transform the input with the 8 symmetries of a square, pass each version through the model, undo the transform on each output and average the 8 results. The model is not exactly equivariant to rotation, so averaging cancels part of the disagreement between the 8 predictions, at the cost of 8 times the inference time. This is the "EDSR + 8× self-ensemble" row in Table 1.

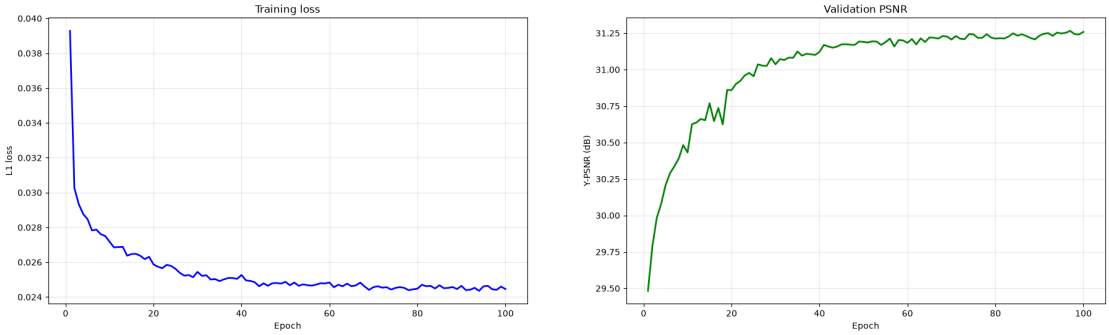
MATLAB-compatible bicubic resize. The DIV2K low-resolution images were produced with MATLAB's `imresize`, whose cubic kernel uses the Keys parameter $a = -0.5$ and applies antialiasing when downscaling. PyTorch's bicubic interpolation uses $a = -0.75$ and no antialiasing, so it is not the inverse of the degradation that created the dataset. We therefore implemented the MATLAB version ourselves. A resize is a linear and separable operation, so we build the interpolation weights as one matrix per axis and apply them to rows and then to columns. This function produces the Bicubic row of Table 1.

4.2 Quantitative Analysis

Here we present the evaluation of training stability, measured through the L1 loss used as the training objective, followed by final performance on the three metrics required for this project: Peak Signal-to-Noise Ratio (PSNR), Structural Similarity (SSIM) and Learned Perceptual Image Patch Similarity (LPIPS).

4.2.1 Training Curves

The model was optimized using **L1 Loss** (Mean Absolute Error). As shown in Figure 2a, the loss decreased steadily over the 100 epochs, indicating that the network converged without divergence. In parallel we monitored the **PSNR** on the 10-image validation set held out of the training pool (Figure 2b); it improves rapidly during the early epochs and continues to gain marginal improvements toward the end of training.



(a) L1 training loss.

(b) Validation PSNR.

Figure 2: **Training curves over 100 epochs.** (a) The training loss shows a consistent downward trend, confirming effective learning without divergence. (b) The validation PSNR increases steadily, reaching a peak of 31.27 dB. This curve is measured on the 10 images held out of the training pool for checkpoint selection, not on the test set, which is why it sits above the 30.41 dB reported in Table 1: the validation set is both smaller and the set the checkpoint was chosen on. The gap is expected once selection and reporting are separated.

4.2.2 Final Quantitative Evaluation

We evaluated our proposed **EDSR** model at scale $\times 4$ on our test set, that is the 100 official DIV2K validation images, which were held out entirely until this point. We compared it against the standard Bicubic baseline and three published methods (A+, SRCNN, VDSR). The results were calculated on the Y-channel (luminance) to ensure consistency with standard benchmarks.

Table 1 presents the complete performance comparison.

Table 1: Quantitative Comparison on the DIV2K test set, i.e. the 100 official validation images (Scale $\times 4$)

Method	**Y-PSNR (dB)**	**Y-SSIM**	**LPIPS ↓**
Bicubic (Calculated)	28.09	0.7744	0.4139
A+ [1]	-	-	-
SRCNN [2]	27.15	0.7780	-
VDSR [3]	28.00	0.7960	-
EDSR (Ours)	**30.41**	**0.8371**	**0.2804**
EDSR + $8\times$ self-ensemble (Ours)	**30.48**	**0.8384**	0.2828

Observation: Our EDSR implementation significantly outperforms the Bicubic baseline and earlier deep learning approaches such as SRCNN and VDSR. Specifically, the model achieved a PSNR of **30.41 dB**, representing a substantial improvement of +2.32 dB over the Bicubic baseline and +2.41 dB over VDSR. Furthermore, the low LPIPS score of 0.2804 confirms that the reconstructed images exhibit superior perceptual quality, effectively recovering high-frequency structural details that are typically lost in simpler methods. The $8\times$ self-ensemble adds a further +0.07 dB in PSNR and a small gain in SSIM, at the cost of a marginally worse LPIPS (0.2828 vs. 0.2804) and $8\times$ the inference time.

4.3 Qualitative Analysis

We provide visual comparisons below on specific examples from the test set.

Figure 3 shows a night city scene dominated by straight edges and repeated window patterns. The Bicubic baseline smears the illuminated facades into soft bands, whereas the proposed model keeps individual windows separated and the roof lines sharp.

We also observe improvements in high-frequency textures, as shown in Figure 4, a close-up of the spiralling centre of a rose. The Bicubic baseline blurs the overlapping petal edges into a single smooth gradient, while the EDSR model recovers the individual folds and the sharp boundary between the lit and shadowed sides of each petal.

5 Conclusion and Limitations

We implemented Single Image Super-Resolution with the EDSR architecture, following Lim et al. [4], and trained it for 100 epochs on the VUB ETRO GPU farm. On a test set held out until the final evaluation it reaches 30.41 dB Y-PSNR, against 28.09 dB for bicubic interpolation, and it wins on SSIM and LPIPS as well. The $8\times$ self-ensemble adds a further 0.07 dB at eight times the inference cost.

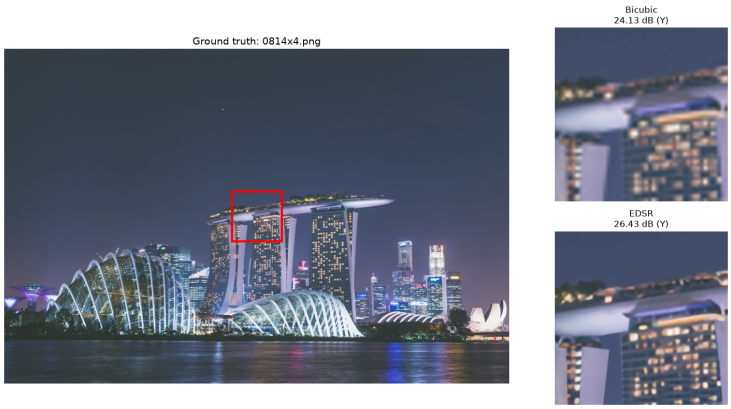


Figure 3: **Geometric Structures (Img 0814):** The Bicubic interpolation blurs the illuminated building facades, whereas the EDSR model preserves sharper window and roof boundaries, resulting in an improvement of **+2.30 dB** in PSNR (24.13 to 26.43 dB on the crop shown).



Figure 4: **High-Frequency Textures (Img 0843):** In the Bicubic version the petal folds at the centre of the rose merge into a smooth gradient. The EDSR model separates them again, resulting in an improvement of **+5.31 dB** in PSNR (26.20 to 31.51 dB on the crop shown).

5.1 Limitations and Observations

Our results come with a number of caveats, and one of our own measurements points the wrong way.

1. **Not everything we changed made things better.** The 8× self-ensemble raises PSNR and SSIM but makes LPIPS worse, from 0.2804 to 0.2828. Averaging eight predictions pulls the output towards the mean of the plausible reconstructions, which is what a pixel-wise metric rewards and what a perceptual metric penalises. For eight times the inference cost we buy 0.07 dB and lose a little perceptual

quality, which is a bad trade outside a benchmark table.

2. **We only model one kind of degradation.** Every low-resolution image we train and test on was produced by MATLAB bicubic downscaling. A real photograph that is simply small has been through sensor noise, compression and an unknown resampling filter. We have no evidence about how the model behaves on those, and we would expect it to do considerably worse.

3. **More training would not rescue this.** The validation curve is close to flat over the last thirty epochs, so the model has essentially converged. What limits the result is the capacity of the network and the size of the training set, not how long we ran it. Getting a materially better number means changing the architecture or training on more data, which is the experiment we deliberately did not run this time.

4. **One run, one seed, no error bars.** We trained each configuration once. That is enough to separate 28.09 from 30.41, but it is not enough to say that the 0.07 dB from the self-ensemble is real rather than noise.

5. **The validation set is small.** Ten images are enough to rank checkpoints, but the peak of 31.27 dB on that set should not be read as a performance estimate. The test-set number is the one that means anything.

6. **The model is heavy.** The residual body and the self-ensemble make inference far slower than interpolation, which rules this out for real-time use such as live video upscaling without further work on quantization or distillation.

References

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[3] Kim, Jiwon et al. “Accurate Image Super-Resolution Using Very Deep Convolutional Networks.” 2016 IEEE Conference on Computer Vision and Pattern Recognition (CVPR) (2016): 1646–1654.

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